

Spring

<http://spring.clan-sy.com>

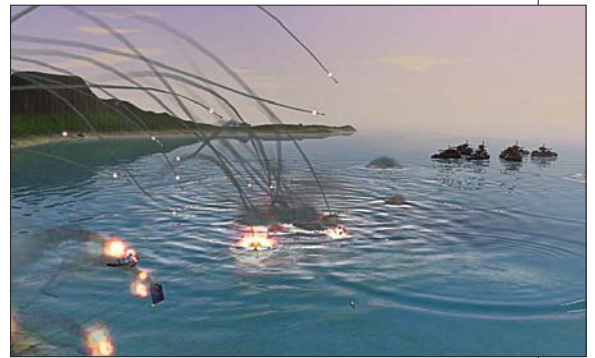
Fancy being a commander of a vast robot army? Do you want to rain down death and destruction upon your enemies? (Need we ask this?) Well, here's one chance: *Spring*, a free and open source game based on *Total Annihilation*.

This is an RTS where you command an army of fearsome robots. (May we emphasise the "fearsome"? It is best played in multiplayer mode, which has lots of options for maps and campaigns, though you have one single-player practice campaign. You start by controlling the Commander, a fighter-worker droid, and construct vehicle plants, bot fab units, energy farms—the works. The resources are—interestingly—metal and energy; you could also build machines to convert energy into metal. You'll need to build fast and furiously, and continuously lay claim to resource-rich areas.

The game AI is robust. For instance, set a fighter plane to bomb a facility and it will, unless attacked from the ground, fly more than one sortie to get the job done! Shoot missiles at planes, and they will arc and swoop until the target is blasted into, you guessed it, smithereens.

The cool thing is, *Spring* does not demand familiarity with the RTS genre. And though they're fearsome, we must admit that if you're good at controlling human characters in RTSes, you can control the bots here.

Rating: 7/10



The Armada gets a roaring welcome



Lin City - NG

<http://lincity-ng.berlios.de>

For aspiring city planners buried under loads of FPS, RPG, and RTS games, *Lin City - NG* comes like a breath of fresh air (or smog, if you want to be brutally realistic). It is a refurbished and slicker open source and free version of the classic city simulation game *Lin City*. Go ahead and unleash the Corbusier in you!

So well, naturally, you start off with a random village or an empty space. The terrain is mostly flat with water bodies thrown in. With an initial corpus, you start constructing communes, residences, roads, schools, industries—the works, literally. As the simulation progresses, your tech levels increase and the city will expand, forcing you to deal with all the problems a modern city planner faces—population pressures, spiralling pollution, infrastructure bottlenecks, creation of employment opportunities... yes, it's that realistic!

On a sad note, if you can't make city liveable, your citizens will die and you'll lose the game

(their lung cancer shall be upon your head). But if your city is flourishing, you reach the high-point of technological development, and... now hear this—you're considered just too advanced, and you get the option to evacuate your citizens using rockets! Some warped imagination at work here...

The highpoint of *Lin City - NG* is definitely the graphics. They are mind-blowing, and we won't go into more elaborate adjective use. The UI is a bit confusing initially, though.

On the downside, newbies are likely to be hampered by the lack of a tutorial, and the water bodies don't have depth, as in, rivers look like puddles.

Lin City-NG was the Linux Game Tome game of the month in January 2005.

Rating: 7/10



3... 2... 1... Fire!

Flight Gear

<http://www.flightgear.org>

If you love flight simulators and want something that can be played outside of Windows, and also have played *Microsoft Flight Simulator*—pretty much top dog in this genre—too much (or can't afford it), *Flight Gear* is what will fit the bill. It is a realistic, sophisticated, and highly extensible game that has been in development for about 10 years—and has finally come of age.

Flight Gear is all about options. You could fly the Wright flyer (yes, that stringed contraption from Kitty Hawk) or break the sonic barrier in the cockpit of the Concorde. They even have a UFO (in case you want to know how our green friends manoeuvre those saucers). Could you ask for more? The choices are equally esoteric in terms of locales, and you can take

